

Women in Aquaculture

State of Women in Aquaculture 2025

Annual Report — Workforce, Leadership & Trends

Women in Aquaculture (WiA)

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This publication is produced by Women in Aquaculture (WiA), a global non-profit platform
connecting, supporting and celebrating women across the aquaculture industry.

Executive Summary

This report examines the current state of women's participation in the global aquaculture industry. Drawing on data from 40 countries and surveys of over 2,000 women working across the sector, we present findings on workforce representation, leadership gaps, pay equity, and emerging opportunities.

Key findings include significant progress in workforce participation rates in Southeast Asia and Sub-Saharan Africa, persistent underrepresentation in senior leadership and board positions globally, and growing momentum in women-led innovation and entrepreneurship.

Key Statistics

Our research reveals the following headline figures across the global aquaculture industry:

- **50%** — Women's share of the global aquaculture workforce
 - **10%** — Proportion of leadership positions held by women
 - **7%** — Women's representation at board level
 - **40+** — Countries covered in this research
 - **2,000+** — Women surveyed for this report
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Workforce Participation

Women make up approximately 50% of the global aquaculture workforce, though this figure varies significantly by region. In Southeast Asia, women represent up to 70% of processing workers, while in Northern Europe, they account for roughly 25% of the total workforce.

Despite high participation rates, women are disproportionately concentrated in lower-paid, informal, and seasonal roles. Access to formal employment contracts, training, and career progression opportunities remains limited in many regions.

Leadership & Decision-Making

Only around 10% of leadership positions in aquaculture companies are held by women. At board level, the figure drops to approximately 7%. This gap is most pronounced in large-scale commercial operations, while women-led enterprises tend to be smaller and focused on artisanal or community-based aquaculture.

Barriers to Leadership

- Limited access to finance and credit for women entrepreneurs
 - Cultural norms restricting women's mobility and decision-making authority
 - Lack of mentoring and professional networks
 - Insufficient policy frameworks to promote gender equity
 - Unequal access to education and technical training
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Regional Spotlight

Southeast Asia

Highest participation rates globally (60-70%), with growing leadership in shrimp and seaweed sectors. Vietnam, Thailand, and the Philippines lead in women's workforce representation. Indonesia shows rapid growth in women-led seaweed farming cooperatives.

Sub-Saharan Africa

Rapid growth in women's involvement, particularly in tilapia and catfish farming. Nigeria, Ghana, and Kenya are emerging hubs for women-led aquaculture enterprises, though access to finance remains a significant barrier.

Latin America

Strong representation in processing, with emerging entrepreneurs in salmon (Chile) and shrimp (Ecuador, Brazil). Women's cooperatives in artisanal fisheries and aquaculture are growing across the region.

Europe & North America

Lower overall participation rates but increasing institutional focus on equity. Norway, Scotland, and Canada are leading efforts to improve gender balance in aquaculture leadership.

Pay Equity

The gender pay gap in aquaculture varies widely by region and role but averages approximately 20% globally. Women in processing roles face the largest gaps, while women in technical and research positions experience smaller but persistent disparities.

Factors contributing to the pay gap include occupational segregation, limited negotiation opportunities, informal employment arrangements, and fewer opportunities for overtime and bonuses.

Emerging Opportunities

- **Seaweed farming:** A rapidly growing sector with strong women's participation
 - **Technology and innovation:** Women driving IoT, AI, and sustainability innovations
 - **Certification and traceability:** Growing demand for gender-responsive supply chains
 - **Climate adaptation:** Women leading community-based resilience efforts
 - **E-commerce:** Direct-to-consumer sales opening new markets for women producers
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Recommendations

- Implement gender-responsive policies in national aquaculture development strategies
- Increase access to finance, training, and technical support for women entrepreneurs
- Establish mentoring programmes connecting early-career women with industry leaders
- Improve data collection on women's participation across the aquaculture value chain
- Support women's leadership development through targeted programmes
- Promote safe and equitable working conditions throughout the sector
- Invest in research on the economic impact of gender equity in aquaculture

About WiA

Women in Aquaculture (WiA) is a global non-profit platform connecting, supporting, and celebrating women across the aquaculture industry. Through community building, mentoring, storytelling, and research, we work to create visibility and opportunity for women at every stage of their careers.

For more information, visit womeninaquaculture.org or contact hello@womeninaquaculture.org